



Specifying and Analyzing Transactional Consistency Models with Predicates

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A semantic and graph-theoretic foundation for predicate operations

Item Operations vs. Predicate Operations

Read(x, v)

Write(x, v)

point access

returns one value

Employee

EID	Salary
X	8
Y	10
Z	6

PredRead(P, M)

$P : \text{Salary} < 9$

condition-based access

returns a set M of **matched** values

What we know about transactional consistency models
without predicates

Review: Intuitive or Operational Specs

Eswaran et al., 1976

The Notions of Consistency and Predicate Locks in a Database System

K.P. Eswaran, J.N. Gray,
R.A. Lorie, and I.L. Traiger
IBM Research Laboratory
San Jose, California

SER

serial execution

Berenson et al., 1995

A Critique of ANSI SQL Isolation Levels

Hal Berenson
Phil Bernstein
Jim Gray
Jim Melton
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SI

snapshot + write-conflict control

Review: Axiomatic Specs

Cerone, Bernardi, and Gotsman, 2015

A Framework for Transactional Consistency Models with Atomic Visibility

Andrea Cerone, Giovanni Bernardi, and Alexey Gotsman

IMDEA Software Institute, Madrid, Spain

(VIS, AR)

Crooks et al., 2017

Seeing is Believing: A Client-Centric Specification of Database Isolation

Natacha Crooks

The University of Texas at Austin and Cornell University

Lorenzo Alvisi

The University of Texas at Austin and Cornell University

Yuer Pu

Cornell University

Allen Clement

Google, Inc.

Client-Centric Views

Complexity:OOPSLA2019

On the Complexity of Checking Transactional Consistency

RANADEEP BISWAS, Université de Paris, IRIF, CNRS, France

CONSTANTIN ENEA, Université de Paris, IRIF, CNRS, France

Checking Complexity

Review: Dependency Graphs

Adya, 1999

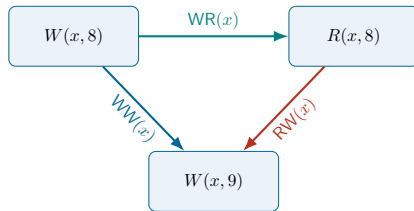
Weak Consistency: A Generalized Theory and Optimistic Implementations for Distributed Transactions

by

Atul Adya

Submitted to the Department of Electrical Engineering and Computer Science
in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of

Doctor of Philosophy



Review: SER Characterization Theorem

Adya, 1999

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Bernstein, Hadzilacos, and Goodman, 1987

**Concurrency Control
and Recovery
in Database Systems**

P.A. BERNSTEIN • V. HADZILACOS • N. GOODMAN

Theorem (roughly stated)

*An item-operation history is serializable iff
its dependency graph is acyclic.*

Review: SI Characterization Theorem

Cerone and Gotsman, 2018

Analysing Snapshot Isolation

ANDREA CERONE, Imperial College London, UK
ALEXEY GOTSMAN, IMDEA Software Institute, Spain

Theorem (roughly stated)

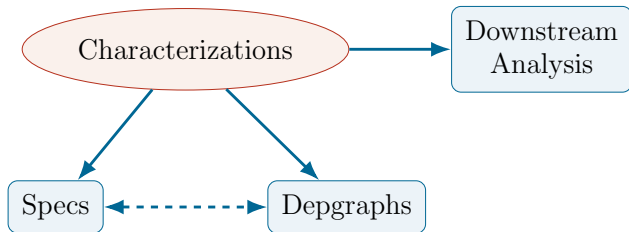
An item-operation history satisfies SI iff every cycle of its dependency graph has at least two adjacent RW edges.

Review: Downstream Analysis Tasks

Task	Representative work
Black-box checking	Kingsbury and Alvaro, 2020; Tan et al., 2020; Huang et al., 2023; Cai et al., 2025
CC protocol verification	Xiong, 2020
Robustness	Bernardi and Gotsman, 2016

Review (Summary)

What we know about transactional consistency models
without predicates



What we know about transactional consistency models
with predicates

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SI

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Review: Axiomatic Specs

Bouajjani, Enea, and Román-Calvo, 2025

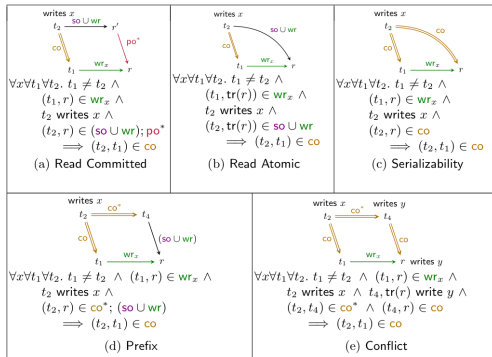
On the Complexity of Checking Mixed Isolation Levels for SQL Transactions

Ahmed Bouajjani¹, Constantin Enea², and Enrique Román-Calvo¹



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cenea@lix.polytechnique.fr



On checking complexity and algorithms

Review: Dependency Graphs

Adya, 1999

Weak Consistency: A Generalized Theory and Optimistic Implementations for Distributed Transactions

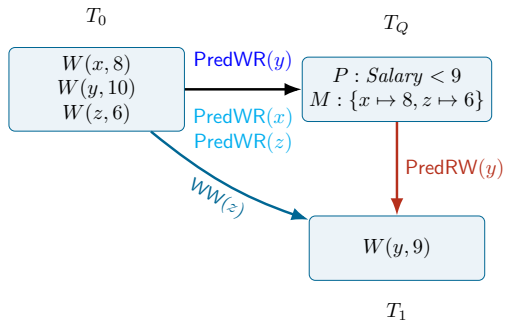
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T_Q also “observes” **unmatched** $W(y, 10)$ of T_0



T_1 later than T_0 **changes matches** of T_Q on y

Review: Dependency Graphs

Predicate-read-dependency, $T \xrightarrow{\text{PredWR}(x)} S$, definitions differ.

Predicate-anti-dependency, $T \xrightarrow{\text{PredRW}(x)} S$, definitions differ.

Adya, 1999

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S changes matches

Sun and Zou, 2025

Vbox: Efficient Black-Box Serializability Verification

Anonymous Author(s)

the “earliest” S

Complexity:CAV2025

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Ahmed Bouajjani¹, Constantin Enea², and Enrique Román-Calvo¹

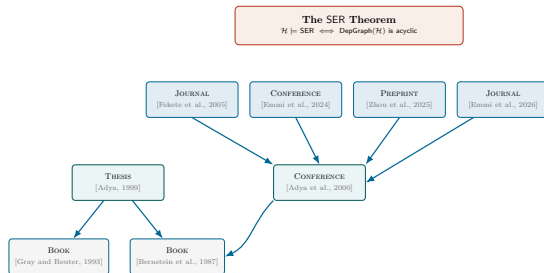


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no “change matches”

Review: SER Characterization



3.4 Correctness and Flexibility of the New Specifications

Our conditions for PL-3 provide the well-known notion of conflict-serializability [BHG87, GR93]. That is, $DSG(H)$ is acyclic, and G1a, and G1b are satisfied for a history H iff H is conflict-serializable. We can prove the equivalence of our PL-3 conditions with conflict-serializability using the proof given in [GR93]; our DSGs are similar to their graphs. This equivalence can also be proved along the lines of the proof given in [BHG87] for view-serializability.

No rigorous proof in the literature

Review: SI Characterization

Adya, 1999

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Theorem 2: A history H consisting of committed transactions executes under Snapshot Isolation iff G1 and G-SI are disallowed.

G-SIa: Low-level *start-depends* $\prec_t$ relation

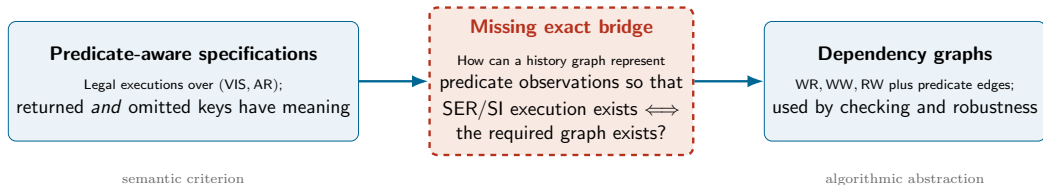
Definition 17: **Snapshot Read.** All reads performed by a transaction T_i occur at its start point. That is, if $r_i(x_j)$ occurs in history H , then:

1. $c_j \prec_t s_i$, and
2. if $w_k(x_k)$ also occurs in H ($j \neq k$), then either
 - (a) $s_i \prec_t c_k$, or
 - (b) $c_k \prec_t s_i$ and $x_k \ll x_j$

Definition 18: **Snapshot Write.** If T_i and T_j are concurrent, they cannot both modify the same object. That is, if $w_i(x_i)$ and $w_j(x_j)$ both occur in history H , then either $c_i \prec_t s_j$ or $c_j \prec_t s_i$. This is the first-committer-wins property.

Proof based on *item-only* properties of SI

The Missing Bridge

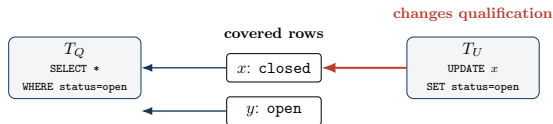


The gap

Predicate-aware **specifications** say which executions are legal; predicate **dependency graphs** are useful only when an *exact, two-way characterization* connects them. That bridge is established for item operations, but was missing for predicate observations.

Cerone and Gotsman, 2018; Bouajjani, Enea, and Román-Calvo, 2025; Adya, 1999; Sun and Zou, 2025

Why Predicates Make the Bridge Nontrivial



Key observation: $x \notin \text{result}$
still records an observation of x .

Item read: records the value of one named key.

Predicate read: observes a *set*: both returned keys and covered keys that are absent.

A concurrent write can therefore change the result by making an absent key match—the classical phantom.

A graph edge must carry enough information to explain that absence.

Berenson et al., 1995; Adya, 1999

What the Missing Bridge Must Deliver

Semantic side

A predicate observation is explained by the latest visible version of every externally observed key, including an omitted key.

Graph side

Predicate read- and anti-dependencies must encode the explanatory version and every observation-changing later write.

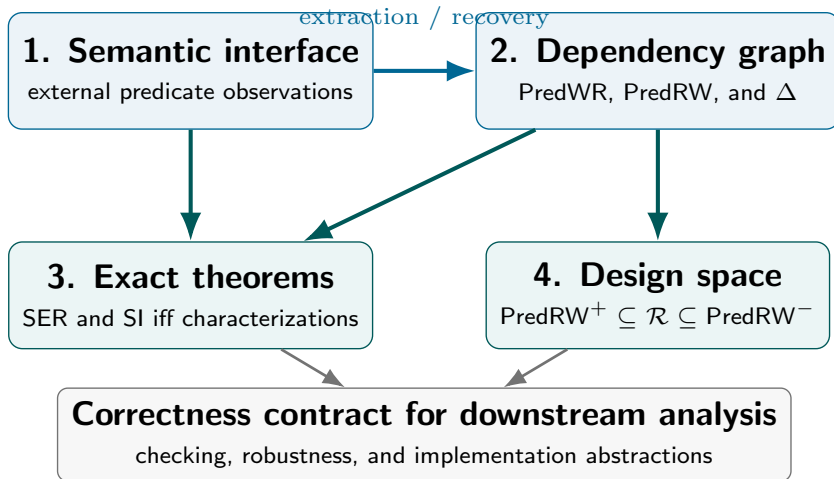
Characterization obligation

SER/SI execution exists $\iff$ a graph satisfying the corresponding criterion exists.

The reverse implication is the hard one: construct a legal execution *from* a graph without losing predicate semantics.

Cerone and Gotsman, 2018

Contributions: Build and Exploit the Bridge



Four Contributions, One Coherent Story

1. **Semantic interface.** Extend (VIS, AR) with item-wise external predicate observations, so both returned and omitted keys have a precise version explanation.
2. **Predicate dependency graphs.** Define PredWR for the explanatory writer and observation-sensitive PredRW using the change predicate Δ .
3. **Exact SER/SI characterizations.** Prove the same execution-graph equivalence style as the item-only results, while resolving the predicate-specific SI witness ambiguity.
4. **Proof-theoretic design space.** Show that every relation between a lower frontier and an upper structural closure preserves the same existential history-level characterization.

Cerone and Gotsman, 2018; Adya, 1999; Bouajjani, Enea, and Román-Calvo, 2025; Sun and Zou, 2025

Claim Boundary: Theory First, Engineering Enabled

We establish

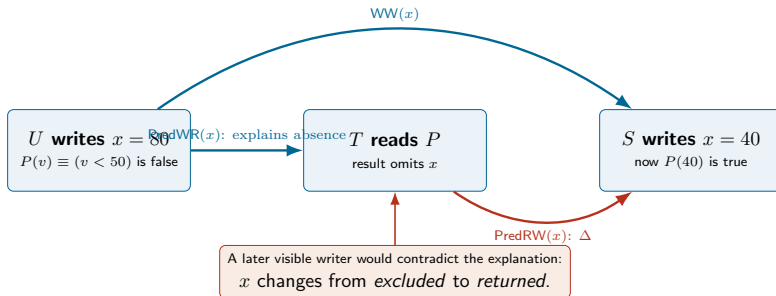
- a predicate-aware semantic-graph correspondence;
- exact graph criteria for SER and SI; and
- a sound interval of admissible predicate anti-dependencies.

We deliberately do not claim

- a new full SQL black-box checker or a cost improvement;
- that every DBMS lock event is literally a graph edge; or
- that the interval relations have identical fixed-graph edges.

The contribution is a reusable correctness contract for those downstream tools.

Technical Insight 1: Make Absence a First-Class Observation



External predicate consistency

For each externally observed key x , choose the AR-latest writer visible to the reader. Its value must equal the returned value when x appears in the result, and must fail the predicate when x is omitted.

Technical Insight 2: Witnesses Turn a Semantic Mismatch into an Edge

Graph witness

$U \xrightarrow{\text{PredWR}(x)} T$ states that U supplies the version by which T externally observes x .

Observation-changing successor

If $U \xrightarrow{\text{WW}(x)} S$ and replacing U 's value by S 's value changes membership or the returned value, then

$$T \xrightarrow{\text{PredRW}(x)} S.$$

Proof move

In the graph-to-execution direction, assume the constructed execution violates an external predicate observation. The graph witness and the execution's latest visible writer then disagree in an observable way, forcing PredRW and hence a forbidden order/cycle.

Predicate analogue of recovering read-from facts from a graph.

Technical Insight 3: Keep Exactly the Proof-Relevant Edges

$$\text{PredRW}^+ \subseteq \mathcal{R} \subseteq \text{PredRW}^-$$

Lower frontier

The earliest later write that changes the observation. It is enough to expose a predicate-consistency violation.

Baseline

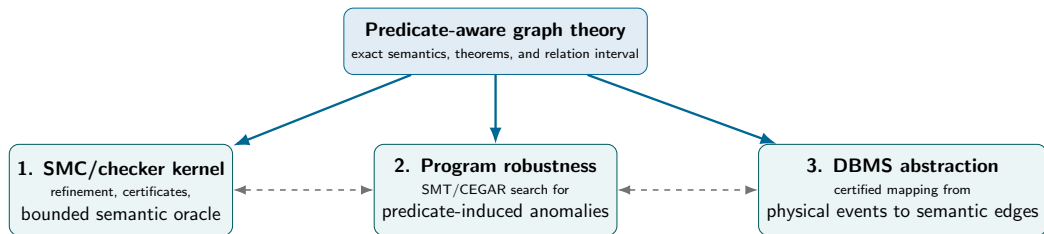
All observation-changing later writers. This is the direct “changes matches” reading.

Upper closure

All later writers sharing a PredWR/WW witness. It is safe to orient in a witnessing execution.

Different fixed graphs; the same existential SER/SI history characterization. The theorem separates correctness from representation.

Future Work: Downstream Analysis Tasks



Three directions share one prerequisite: preserve the semantic bridge while moving from histories to algorithms and implementations.

1. Predicate-Aware Stateless Model Checking

Theory-guided checker kernel

From normalized predicate histories, construct a common PredWR/WW base and use lower/baseline/upper relations for SER/SI checks. A lower persistent cycle can reject; an upper acyclic graph can accept; ambiguous cases are refined or solved.

Make it scientifically credible

- validate against exhaustive bounded (VIS, AR) search;
- emit a checkable witness/cycle certificate; and
- measure edge density, Δ tests, memory, and solver work.

The target is a relation-policy laboratory or SMC kernel—not merely another end-to-end black-box checker.

Bouajjani, Enea, and Román-Calvo, 2025; Sun and Zou, 2025

2–3. Program Robustness and Faithful Implementations

2. Predicate-aware robustness analysis

Lift item-only robustness questions from histories to transaction programs: do all SI executions of a program remain serializable when predicate reads can create phantoms? A finite predicate/write abstraction and the graph criterion can drive SMT/CEGAR search for a violating program path.

Success: a sound abstraction theorem and counterexample traces that explain the decisive predicate edge.

3. Certified mapping from DBMS events

Relate recorded predicate/range-conflict events to semantic keys, writer order, coverage, and Δ . Prove when a mechanism is a sound lower or upper approximation, rather than labeling physical locks as semantic edges by fiat.

Success: one DBMS adapter with a stated abstraction theorem and certificates validated against captured histories.

Fekete et al., 2005; Bernardi and Gotsman, 2016; Cerone and Gotsman, 2018